GEOGRAPHY IN HISTORY

1.6 Native American Environments

MAIN IDEA Before European settlement, 500 Native American tribes inhabited North America. Geography helped to shape their diverse cultures.

PHYSICAL AND HUMAN GEOGRAPHY

When you examine how geography affected people and culture, you are taking a **geographic perspective**. That is, you are looking at culture through the lens of geography. You can examine two aspects of geography: physical geography and human geography.

Physical geography refers to the physical characteristics of a region. It includes the surface of the earth, soil, bodies of water, climate, and glaciers and ice sheets. It also includes plant and animal life.

Human geography examines how people and their cultures are affected by physical geography, and how human activities affect the environment. For example, geography has a great impact on how people make a living. People who live near the sea often make a living by fishing, and in regions with fertile soils, farming is usually an important economic activity.

Use physical geography and human geography to study these Native American tribes before the arrival of Christopher Columbus in the Americas. For each group, you will find an explanation of their physical geography and human geography.



Carved polar bear knife handle, Alaska



Earthenware bowl, New Mexico

Stone point, Eastern Woodlands

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PHYSICAL GEOGRAPHY	HUMAN GEOGRAPHY
ARCTIC AND SUBARCTIC	
The Inuit, Aleut, and other tribes of this region lived in one of the harshest environments on Earth—the land that we now call Alaska. It is a land of snow and ice, with little vegetation in the winter.	The people living in the far north creatively adapted to their harsh environment. They hunted for seals and whales and built igloos out of ice to protect themselves from the extreme cold.
NORTHWEST COAST	
The tribes of the Northwest Coast lived in the region that is now the states of Washington and Oregon and the Canadian province of British Columbia. It is a rich environment with lush forests and rivers filled with fish.	The tribes of the Northwest included the Chinook and the Tlingit. They fished and hunted for bears and other large game. The abundance of the region allowed families to accumulate wealth. Families gained honor by giving away part of their wealth in a ceremony called the potlatch.
GREAT BASIN AND PLATEAU	
This region, west of the Great Plains, features soaring mountains and plateaus with long stretches of grassland. The land supported large mammals, including antelope, moose, elk, mountain goat, and bison.	The Utes, Shoshone, and other tribes hunted for game and fished in the rivers for salmon and trout. Some Native Americans even created dances to mimic the movement of the grass in the wind.
SOUTHWEST	
The Southwest, which includes today's Arizona and New Mexico, is a region of deserts with very little rainfall. The climate is harsh, with temperatures soaring to 110 degrees Fahrenheit or more in the summer. But the region also has rivers.	The rivers are critical to this region because of the lack of rainfall. The Pueblo tribes, who lived near the Rio Grande in what is now New Mexico, planted maize (corn) and other crops near the river.
GREAT PLAINS	
The Great Plains stretch from present-day Iowa to Wyoming. The region is flat, with plains and tallgrass prairies. The most important resource was once the bison, or buffalo, which numbered at least 30 million in the 1400s.	The Great Plains had many tribes, including the Lakota, the Blackfoot, and the Mandan. These tribes had one thing in common—they used the bison for food, shelter, and clothing.
NORTHEAST	
The Northeast region spans the present-day states from Virginia to Maine. This land has ample rainfall, many rivers and streams, and a wealth of natural resources, including wild game, fish, and fertile soil.	The Algonquian- and Iroquois-speaking people who lived in this region used the many rivers and streams as highways. They built canoes out of wood and birchbark to use for long-distance trading.
SOUTHEAST	
The Southeast reaches from today's North Carolina to Florida and offers many natural gifts: a mild climate, plentiful rainfall, and fertile soil.	The Cherokee, the Choctaw, and other groups grew maize, beans, squash, and other crops in the fertile soil. Because of the mild climate, the land supported a large population and tribes thrived.

THINK LIKE A GEOGRAPHER

1. **IDENTIFY MAIN IDEAS AND DETAILS** How did different Native American groups adapt to the amount of rainfall they received?
2. **MAKE INFERENCES** What does the potlatch reveal about the attitudes toward wealth among Native Americans of the Northwest?

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